

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 02~09~2026
-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-
"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"
Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You
Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts
All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or
indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.
There are some topics which can be coded in answer
writing of other topics in the main exam.

BANK SANCTIONS LIKELY THIS WEEK, SAYS BESSANT

US launches new barrage of strikes on Iran around Strait

Tehran will be hit again at a much harder and higher level, says Trump

Reuters
Dubai, Washington,
September 1

THE US launched new air strikes on Iranian targets on Tuesday, quashing hopes that an exchange of fire last weekend might not lead to a wider renewal of hostilities.

Tehran remained defiant, warning that it would prevent oil being exported from the Gulf, despite a threat by US President Donald Trump to hit Iran "hard" in response to the renewed Iranian strikes, and a warning from US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessant that Washington was about to impose new sanctions.

"Today at 12 pm ET (1600 GMT), US forces began striking Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) targets in Iran," US Central Command posted on X. "The strikes follow recent attempted attacks by the IRGC against commercial shipping in the Strait of Hormuz and against American service members deployed to the region."

Iran's state broadcaster said there had been reports of explosions on Iran's Qeshm Island, on the northern side of the strait.

The state-linked news agency *Nour News* said there had been reports of explosions in the port city of Bandar Abbas and in Chabahar, a port on the southern coast. *IRNA* also reported the sound of explosions in Jask and Sirik.

US President Donald



Iran President Masoud Pezeshkian during a session of the SCO summit in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, on Tuesday. REUTERS

Trump posted on his social media channel that if Iran retaliated for the attack, "they will be hit again at a much harder and higher level".

The *Fars* news cited an IRGC spokesperson as saying the US "will regret its new attacks".

The US Embassy in Qatar urged Americans currently in the Middle East to exercise "heightened vigilance and be aware of potential flight cancellations, airspace closures, and travel disruptions".

Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian had said early on Tuesday at a regional summit in Kyrgyzstan that Tehran would reciprocate immediately if Washington honoured its commitments under a June Memorandum of Understanding that was intended to halt the conflict.

The MOU declared an end to fighting since US and Israeli strikes began on February 28. But it also deferred many of the difficult issues and paved the way for a broader 60-day negotiation period — which passed without further agreement.

Iranian officials have shown no public sign since then of bowing to pressure. "If the enemy wants us not to export oil from the Persian Gulf, no one will be able to export oil," Iranian parliament speaker Mohammad Baqer Ghalibaf was quoted as saying by Iranian media.

Foreign Ministry spokesman Esmail Baghaei told a press conference in Tehran that Washington was "addicted to making excessive demands and has mistaken negotiations for dictating terms".

Before the latest attacks, Bessant had said Washington was likely to announce bank sanctions against Iran this week and next, stepping up an attempt to "economically asphyxiate" Iran's leadership after six months of conflict.

At a G20 finance leaders' meeting in Asheville, North Carolina, he said the US was looking to target entities that did business with the IRGC. "We have zero tolerance. We are going to economically asphyxiate this regime," he said.

At SCO summit, Xi urges member states to make security a priority

Press Trust of India
Bishkek, September 1

CHINESE PRESIDENT Xi Jinping on Tuesday called on the members of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) to make security a key priority and crack down on terrorism, separatism and extremism, transnational organised crimes, drug trafficking and telecom fraud.

"We should stay committed to taking security as a key goal, and foster an environment of common security. We should pursue coordinated measures to tackle traditional and non-traditional security threats," Xi said while addressing the SCO summit in the Kyrgyz capital attended by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Russian President Vladimir Putin and others.

"We should crack down on the three forces of terrorism, separatism and extremism, transnational organised crime, drug trafficking, and telecom fraud," he added.



Kyrgyz President Sadyr Zhaparov (right) and China's President Xi Jinping at the SCO summit, in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan on Tuesday. AP

Xi also spoke about the need for multilateral partnership for nuclear safety and security.

"We believe in a sensible, coordinated, and balanced approach to nuclear security, and support a stronger multilateral partnership for nuclear safety and security," he said. He, however, did not elaborate.

The SCO member states should strengthen cooperation on information security, bio-se-

curity, and outer space security, Xi said.

In a veiled criticism of the US, he said, "We must prevent external forces from interfering in our internal affairs, endangering our political security, and undermining regional stability."

He said over the last 25 years, the SCO has travelled an extraordinary journey and emerged as an important pillar of south-south cooperation.

Congo Ebola cases top 6,000, deaths near 3,000

Associated Press
Bunia, September 1

CONGO'S AUTHORITIES said Monday that the fastest-growing Ebola outbreak in history has topped 6,000 cases with 2,911 deaths.

More than 1,360 people have recovered from the virus, in what authorities said was an "encouraging" development. Last week, the virus spilled into two new health zones in the region.

The World Health Organization has said it remains out of control and is on track to surpass the 2014-2016 West Africa Ebola outbreak, the deadliest on record, which killed over 11,000 people, primarily in Guinea, Liberia and Sierra Leone.

On Saturday, an Ebola response team was attacked on the outskirts of the town of Mambasa in Ituri province while responding to a call to secure a body. Young people armed with machetes stormed the site of the funeral, forcing the team to flee and injuring



Ebola outbreak has triggered a global health concern as WHO monitors rising cases and deaths in Congo. AP

one member, a representative told *The Associated Press*.

"We demand greater security so we can operate in the field and do our work without endangering our lives," said Floribert Magene, a member of the response team.

Bodies of those who died of Ebola can be highly contagious and lead to further spread when people prepare them for burial and gather for funerals. Clinical trials are underway to find a licensed vaccine for the Bundibugyo virus.

• META ACCEPTS IDs TO CHECK AGE, AND PROMISES TO DELETE THEM WITHIN 30 DAYS; BEYOND IDs, A GROWING NUMBER OF TECH COMPANIES ARE USING A.I. TO TRY TO DETERMINE USERS' AGE

To keep children safe online, Meta is trying to get better at guessing their age

Barbara Ortutay
September 1

OF THE child safety measures agreed to in Meta's landmark legal settlement, no category contains more detailed requirements than its commitments on age assurance — and for good reason. No matter how well the protections work, they are of little use if Meta can't tell which users are kids.

Determining which accounts belong to children is also the linchpin of child safety measures that other companies, including Google, TikTok, and Roblox, are ramping up as public and regulatory sentiment turns against them

in the US and other countries.

The Meta settlement, with protections the company says could become industry standards, will give the social media giant a year to refine its approach. But the options are limited, and improving age verification technology presents steep challenges, including navigating privacy implications not just for children but for adults who could have to prove they are over 18.

The \$18 billion settlement resolves claims from state attorneys general that it hurt children's mental health by deliberately designing its Instagram and Facebook platforms in ways hooked young people's at-

tention. The agreement announced last week with Menlo Park, California, company involves 48 states plus District of Columbia and US territories.

In the offline world, people use government-issued IDs to prove they are over 18 or 21, whether they want to get into a club or buy cigarettes. While this technically works online too, many people are not comfortable giving a Big Tech company like Meta or Google access to their driver's license or passport.

Meta accepts IDs to check ages, and promises to delete them within 30 days. Beyond IDs, though, a growing number of tech companies are using artificial intelligence to try to de-



Meta logo on a sign at the company headquarters in California. AP

Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 termine users' ages. This is not true age verification. While AI can estimate a person's age, often accurately, it can't verify a person's birth date.

termines. Meta does the same.

AI age checks use clues to determine how old someone is.

On Instagram, this includes "contextual clues" such as posts about birthday celebrations or school, and things like which posts people like, comment or linger on, who their friends are, and the times of day they log in. For instance, someone who is offline during school hours would likely be school-aged.

In a blog post last year, Meta said its AI also looks at photos people post for visual cues, including "height or bone structure, to estimate someone's general age; it does not identify the specific person in the image."

"By combining these visual

insights with our analysis of text and interactions, we can significantly increase the number of underage accounts we identify and remove," company added.

Under the settlement, Meta agreed to strengthen its age-checking technology using its own tools, as well as third-party ones, with regular outside audits on how well it is working.

The agreement also includes specific goals around false positive rates that is, minors who are identified as over 18. And if a user is identified as under 13 and kicked off one of its platforms,

Meta will check the ages of their friends, too.

Identity verification companies like Yoti and Persona,

which work with tech companies like Meta and Roblox, use video selfies people upload to estimate their ages.

The gaming site Roblox, which, unlike social media platforms, allows kids under 13 to sign up, requires players to take a video selfie to estimate their age. Roblox says the videos are deleted after the age check is processed. Users are not required to submit a face scan to use the platform, only if they want to chat with other users.

Some users have reported inaccuracies, and experts have expressed caution about reliability of facial age estimation tools, especially for women or certain racial or ethnic groups. AP



PM calls for dialogue: Conflict not confined to a region, impacts global energy and trade

At SCO, Modi seeks dismantling of terror infra as Pak’s Shehbaz listens

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, September 1

AS THE war in West Asia completed six months and a peace deal remained elusive, Prime Minister Narendra Modi told leaders of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation countries Tuesday that the crisis demonstrated that a “conflict in one region does not remain confined



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Chinese President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin in Bishkek on Tuesday. REUTERS

there” and “impacts global energy security, maritime trade and supply chains” with the Global South bearing the brunt of the “consequences”.

Addressing the SCO summit in Kyrgyz capital Bishkek, Modi said India’s position is that the “resolution of all tensions and conflicts is possible only through dialogue and diplomacy, not on the battlefield”.

Among leaders at the summit was Iran’s President Masoud Pezeshkian. Modi and Pezeshkian met Monday for the first time since the start of the war .

“In today’s interconnected »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

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EXPRESS investigation

Jharkhand SIR faceoff: BJP agents seek to delete voters, BLOs raise red flag

In Godda, one BJP agent burns 75 forms after Booth Level Officer asks questions; CEO says BLO cannot refuse forms

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, September 1

ABDUL MANNAN Khan, Mohammad Naushad, Mohammad Shafiq, Bibi Basilan, Mohammad Aslam... With voter after voter in some booths in Jharkhand’s Godda district, a pattern has emerged over the past month since the draft electoral roll was published on August 5 as part of the state’s Special Intensive Revision (SIR) — a BJP Booth Level Agent (BLA) arrives with a stack of Form 7s seeking to delete voters who figure in the draft roll; and most of these names, as mentioned above, are from the minority community.

Across at least four booths, Booth Level Officers (BLOs) have refused to accept these applications, an investigation by *The Indian Express* has revealed, flagging them as not genuine or not procedurally sound. BLOs are employees of the state government, currently headed by a JMM-Congress alliance.

The BJP has complained »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Maheshtikri villagers who have complained to the BDO. EXPRESS

• One agent, eight Form 7s

Applications to delete 8 from voter roll filed by BJP agent Sanjeev Roshan



Abdul Mannan Khan Bibi Basilan Mirza Galeeb Mohammad Hasmuddin



Mohammad Naushad Mohammad Shafiq Mohammad Shamim Mohammad Aslam

Behind Form 7: Deletion but only after probe

IN GODDA, Booth Level Officers (BLOs) of at least four booths have said that BJP workers have submitted Form 7s seeking deletion of multiple names. They have also claimed that these forms were not in the proper format, and many of these were rejected, as instructed by the Block Development Officer, Sri-man Marandi.

• What are the legal provisions for deletion from electoral rolls?

Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) are empowered by Section 22 of the Representation of the People (RP) Act, 1950, to make corrections and deletions to the electoral roll either on their own or acting on applications made to them. In each case, they must conduct an inquiry, give the elector concerned time to respond and then pass an order.

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Jharkhand SIR faceoff

that the BLOs are at fault for not accepting the forms, adding a political dimension and setting up a standoff between ground-level election officials and BJP workers, which has now reached the Chief Electoral Officer's desk.

The *Indian Express* tracked down some voters targeted for deletion and found that not only do they trace their presence in the village for generations but many among them are also verified in the 2003 intensive revision of the rolls. Under the Election Commission's own rules, this should ease their inclusion in the ongoing SIR.

In one booth alone, Booth No. 9 of Maheshtikri village in Godda, for example, 25 such forms were filed against voters by one BJP BLA, Sanjeev Kumar Roshan. The *Indian Express* spoke to eight of these voters, and all of them expressed fears of being disenfranchised or cut off from the roster of government schemes.

In a neighbouring booth, a BLA turned up with 75 such forms, and when questioned by the Booth Level Officer (BLO), he, by his own admission, promptly burned them on the spot.

Sriman Marandi, the Block Development Officer (BDO) of Basantrai, the Godda division under which the booths fall, told The *Indian Express* that, in his capacity as Electoral Registration Officer (ERO), he had received complaints from four booths — Maheshtikri, Pachua Kita, Lochni and Baghakol. An inquiry report would be submitted after a field verification, Marandi said, adding BLOs had been told not to act on forms “because we did not know the source of the forms”, “They (the BLAs) could have first submitted a written complaint to the SDO, or to me... asking us to investigate,” he said.

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PM at SCO

world, the scope of security has expanded significantly. The crisis in West Asia has demonstrated that a conflict in one region does not remain confined there. It impacts global energy security, maritime trade and supply chains. The Global South bears the brunt of these consequences. Therefore, India has consistently maintained that the resolution of all tensions and conflicts is possible only through dialogue and diplomacy, not on the battlefield,” the PM said.

And as Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif listened, Modi said, “Terrorism remains a grave challenge for all of humanity. In the fight against it, we cannot limit ourselves to a mere ‘action-reaction’ mindset.”

“We must dismantle the entire ecosystem of terror financing, recruitment, radicalisation and safe havens. We must speak in one voice to declare that there is no room for double standards on this critical issue. Countries that use terrorism as an instrument of state policy and provide shelter and support to terrorists must be sent a strong message: Terrorism cannot be a strategic asset for anyone,” he said.

In May 2025, days after the Pahalgam terror attack, India launched Operation Sindoor, striking terror targets in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir and Pakistan. This led to four days of hostilities which ended with Pakistan seeking a ceasefire.

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

me what the form was for, and said he had been told it was for adding names. I told him that, rather, you are being made a witness that this person's name should be deleted,” Mukhtar said, adding that he did not accept the forms.

Mukhtar said almost all the names on the 75 forms were of Muslims, and most were mapped to the 2003 list. When questioned, the BLA who had tried to submit the 75 forms to him “burned all of them”, he added.

‘This is our home’

In Maheshtikri village, several villagers have submitted a complaint to BDO Marandi regarding mass submission of Form 7s against them in Booth No. 9.

Abdul Mannan Khan, 70, is among them. He and his family have lived in the village for generations, he said, and his name was in the 2003 roll. “This is our home and we are Jharkhandi too. So how can our names be deleted?” BLO Bano has assured them their names will stay, Khan said, but he is afraid he may lose government benefits.

Mohammad Naushad, 50, said his grandparents were mapped to the 2003 electoral roll, while he spent his childhood in Maheshtikri and left home only to find work as a labourer. He continues to vote in Jharkhand, Naushad said. “I go where I get work... What if our names are deleted and we do not get government benefits? What if we are not considered Indian citizens?”

Naushad's father Mohammad Shafiq, 80, said he is a registered voter in Maheshtikri as well, along with wife Bibi Basilan, 65. “I have been voting here since I turned 18... We have been here so many years. We have the khatian (land proof of being a Jharkhandi), every record and paper. Now there is suddenly an obstacle.”

Added Basilan: “Our family will be destroyed... Where will

we go?... What kind of system have they created against voters?”

Mohammad Aslam, 65, also a labourer, said he and all the eligible members of his family have always voted in the village. On the Form 7 application, he said: “It seems like an attempt to establish we do not belong here.”

About what may follow, Aslam is anxious. “We aren't educated enough to understand the consequences.”

Mirza Galeeb, 61, who works in Ghaziabad near Delhi, but is back home, said he was born in Maheshtikri and has spent most of his life in the village. “Everything is here,” he said.

Shamim, around 45, a labourer, said he only came to know about the Form 7 application against him when an anganwadi worker told him. He was surprised, he said. “Everything is fine online with my application. I also have a receipt.”

While he travels outside Jharkhand for work, his family has been based in the state, Shamim said. “Our forefathers lived here. My father and three brothers are here. One brother lives in Bihar and has his voter ID there. Apart from him, our Aadhaar cards, addresses and everything are from Jharkhand.”

Mohammad Hasmuddin, around 60, a daily wage, said he spent his childhood in Maheshtikri, where his family owns land and has a khatian. His name was in the 2003 electoral roll too, and he had voted earlier in Godda, he said.

“My father, grandfather and great-grandfather have all lived in this house. We have not even changed our house,” Hasmuddin said, adding that his son who works in Delhi also returns to the village to vote.

‘Part of BJP responsibility’

On August 27, the BJP's Jharkhand SIR convenor, Rakesh Prasad, submitted a memorandum to the Additional CEO,

complaining about “discrepancies” in the SIR process in the state, particularly in Sahibganj and Godda districts.

In the case of Godda, the BJP accused BLOs of two booths of refusing to accept Form 7 applications submitted by its BLAs, and asked how BLO Bano, of Booth No. 9, Maheshtikri, had made public the details of its BLA. This had resulted in pressure and threats against the BLA, the BJP claimed.

Asked about BLO complaints regarding Form 7s submitted by BJP BLAs, former BJP Godda MLA Amit Kumar Mandal said this is part of their responsibility and they have been trained in this, including in the use of Form 6 (for new voters) and 8 (to record shifting or correction of entries).

“If someone's name is appearing at two places, the BLA can raise an objection for deletion,” said Amit Mandal.

On the allegation that Form 7 documents are being distributed in bulk, with one BLA submitting up to 75, Mandal said there is no prescribed limit on the number of applications a BLA can submit, and that it is the responsibility of the election authorities to verify the objections.

Mandal also said that a BLO must “maintain confidentiality” about the person against whom objections have been filed, as well as of the BLA concerned. “If the BLO has disclosed such information, it can amount to a violation of the Representation of the People Act.”

In the 2024 Assembly elections in Jharkhand, Mandal lost from Godda to Sanjay Yadav of the RJD (a part of the JMM-Congress alliance) by more than 20,000 votes. In the 2020 elections, Mandal defeated Yadav, but by a narrow margin of around 4,500 votes.

BJP BLA Sanjeev Kumar Roshan told The *Indian Express* he was given around 25 Form 7s by ex-MLA Mandal and told to submit the same to the BLO. As per Roshan, Mandal told him: “If the BLO accepts the forms, it is fine; if not, bring them back.” Roshan

said he got some forms back after these were rejected by Maheshtikri's BLO.

Ganori Mandal, the BLA who submitted 75 Form 7 applications to Mukhtar, told The *Indian Express* he had barely any idea what the form was, and confirmed that, when he got to know something was wrong, he “burned” all the forms. “We are innocent and uneducated people. We got the forms from BJP cadres to submit to the BLO. I thought it was a form to add names,” he said.

BDO Marandi questioned the submission of bulk objections. “Any objection should be raised by the family concerned, or there should be solid evidence,” he said.

Marandi added that preliminary information suggested that some of the voters sought to be deleted are living at their registered addresses, and said the administration will conduct a field verification for every deletion request.

Jharkhand Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) K Ravi Kumar said that he had spoken to the Godda Assistant ERO and Deputy Commissioner, and there was no illegality. Objections had been filed through Form 7, he said, and these “can be submitted in bulk as well”.

The CEO added that if a BLA believes a voter is registered in multiple states, they can file an objection. “There is nothing wrong in filing objections.”

He also said that the BLOs should not be rejecting forms: “First, you have to inform the AERO. They will decide what needs to be done. After that, you give your recommendation in the observation report.”

The JMM's local block president, Sultan Ahmed, called the forms part of a “conspiracy by the BJP to remove Muslim voters”.

Congress general secretary Surya Kant Shukla said the party was keeping a close watch on the SIR in Jharkhand, to monitor any attempts to delete names through Form 7. “We condemn any attempt at targeted deletions.”

Voters can be deleted, but not without a probe

The ERO can delete an entry from the electoral roll in case the person has died, or is no longer ordinarily resident in that constituency, or has been found ineligible – meaning, they are not a citizen or are under the age of 18 years.

● How can electors apply for deletion?

Under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, Form 7 must be used for making “objection for proposed inclusion / deletion of name in existing roll”. Electors can file a Form 7 if they want to delete their own name or if they want to object to any other elector in their constituency.

The form can be downloaded from the ECI's voter portal (voters.eci.gov.in) and handed to the BLO concerned or submitted online. The ECINet app can also be used to submit forms online.

● How is Form 7 filed online?

To submit Form 7 online, one has to first create an account and link one's phone number to their electors photo identity card (EPIC) number on the voters' portal or app. Only those registered in the same constituency can submit a Form 7 seeking deletion of a name from a particular constituency.

Form 7 requires the applicant to provide their own name, EPIC number and phone number, as well as the name, EPIC number (if available) and address of the person against whom they are objecting.

The applicant has to select one of five reasons for objecting against an elector: “death”, “under age”, “absent/permanently shifted”, “already enrolled”, or “not Indian citizen”.

The form does not require any evidence. However, the applicant has to sign a declaration that says: “I HEREBY DECLARE that to the best of my knowledge and belief that I am aware that making a statement or declar-

ation which is false and which I know or believe to be false or do not believe to be true, is punishable...”

Once the form is completed, it can be printed for offline submission to the BLO or submitted online.

● How are the forms processed?

Since 2018, the ECI has had a centralised portal for EROs across the country, known as ERONet. Before that, states had their own applications for processing forms.

The ERONet portal standardised the process. However, each form is processed at the level of the ERO concerned and not centrally.

In 2025, the ECI launched a new version of this portal, combining about 40 of its existing apps and portals for voters and officers. Voters who log on to the voters' portal or officers who access ERONet are all redirected to the new ECINet portal.

EROs and Assistant EROs receive the applications filed in their respective areas through the portal for further processing. For each form, the ERO is required to issue a notice to the elector against whom an objection has been filed, give seven days for response, hold a hearing and pass an order. BLOs are required to conduct field visits to verify as well.

● Are there gaps in the online system?

The portal itself does not require any proof at the time of filing a form for deletion. There is also no verification of whether applicants' EPICs and phone numbers actually belong to them.

But, ECI officials point out, safeguards are built into the system through the provisions of the RP Act and Registration of Electors Rules. While the form may be filed online, the deletion can only be carried out after a detailed inquiry by the ERO and the BLO on the ground.

Pregnancy, maternity leave cannot be grounds for demotion at work, says HC

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, September 1

FOR RAKHI Bisht, returning to work after maternity leave should have meant getting back to the career she had built over 14 years. Instead, when she returned to HashiCorp in July 2024, she found her role had been reassigned.

Bisht, a chartered accountant, had joined the software company as an accounting manager in June 2022, drawing Rs 2.6 lakh a month. After taking maternity leave in December 2023, she returned to find herself placed in the treasury department of the company. The duties assigned to her were traditionally performed by a staff accountant — approximately three levels below her designation — and were clerical in nature.

Bisht resigned in October 2024 and moved the Delhi High Court. She sought Rs 50 lakh as compensation and the formulation of strict anti-discrimination guidelines for private companies.

On August 31, the HC directed HashiCorp to pay Bisht Rs 10 lakh in compensation.

“Under no circumstance, can maternity be allowed to become a source of ignominy at the work place,” Justice Sachin Datta said in his order.

“...a harmonious reading of Articles 14, 15, 21 and 42 (of the Constitution) leaves little room for doubt that pregnancy and maternity cannot be treated as grounds for professional disadvantage, demotion, loss of status, or denial of career progression. Such actions undermine not only the statutory protections available to women employees but also the constitutional commitment to equality, dignity, social justice, and humane conditions of work,” he added.

In her petition, Bisht said she was informed there was no position available for her in her original team. The new role, she said, “bore no resemblance to

• WHAT THE COURT SAID

NO CAREER PENALTY: Maternity leave cannot lead to demotion, loss of status or stalled career growth.

EQUIVALENT ROLE: If the post genuinely no longer exists, she must get an equivalent role in pay, grade, status, authority and growth prospects.

EMPLOYER MUST EXPLAIN: Any change must be

communicated with reasons, details of the new role and consideration of the woman's objections.

WOMAN'S OBJECTION MATTERS: If the woman challenges the new role, the employer must give a reasoned response.

SAME POST ON RETURN: A woman should ordinarily return to the position she held before maternity leave.



the managerial accounting position for which she had been hired”. Bisht said the duties assigned in the treasury department undermined her qualifications, experience and professional standing.

The court noted that “neither the Maternity Benefit Act, 1961, nor the Code on Social Security, 2020, expressly prescribes a comprehensive framework for the post-maternity reintegration of women employees”. It added that the absence of such a framework can undermine the effective implementation of the constitutional and statutory protections already in existence.

“...the law cannot be construed in a manner that allows its substantive guarantees to be circumvented through formal or cosmetic compliance,” Justice Datta said.

The court said a woman returning from maternity leave is “ordinarily entitled to be restored to the post held by her immediately prior to proceeding on such leave”.

“For bona fide and demonstrable organisational reasons, the post is no longer available, she is entitled to be placed in a position as nearly equivalent to it as possible in terms of pay, grade, status, role, responsibilities, managerial authority, and prospects for advancement,” Justice Datta said.

He added that employers must also explain why the ear-

lier position is unavailable and provide details of the alternative role, including its grade, remuneration, reporting relationship and duties. If the woman objects, her concerns must be considered and the employer must communicate its decision with reasons.

The court directed HashiCorp — a private software company recently acquired by IBM — to frame rules or schemes or issue directions covering pregnancy-related workplace accommodation, protection of role and status after maternity leave, lactation support, crèche facilities, timelines for disposal of grievances and protection against retaliation. The exercise shall be completed within six months from today, it added.

Further, the HC took note of suggestions made by Union government Standing Counsel Ashish K Dixit, including a proposal that the “protected period” for women employees should span from the initial disclosure of pregnancy until six months after she returns to work.

As per the suggestions, employers would be mandated to conduct individualized assessments within seven days of pregnancy disclosure to provide reasonable workplace accommodations without forcing employees on leave or inferior roles.

The court also directed the firm to pay Bisht Rs 1.5 lakh towards costs.

SC seeks Centre’s views on totaliser use for counting of votes in EVMs

Implementation would help save lives by preventing post-poll violence: Petitioner

Express News Service
New Delhi, September 1

THE SUPREME Court on Tuesday sought the Centre’s views on using a totaliser for counting of votes in clusters recorded in EVMs to ensure voter privacy and prevent their victimisation as opposed to the current mechanism of booth-wise counting.

A three-judge bench presided by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant sought to know if suitable changes could be made to the Conduct of Elections Rules 1961, which allows this in the counting of paper ballots, so that it covers EVMs too.

The bench also comprising Justice Joymalya Bagchi and Justice V Mohana was hearing petitions seeking direction to the EC to declare results for an entire parliamentary constituency instead of revealing booth-wise figures.

Totaliser is a device which allows votes cast in about 14 polling booths to be counted together.

Advocate Ashwini Kumar Upadhyay, one of the petitioners, said implementing the totaliser mechanism would help save lives by preventing post-poll violence.

He submitted that most post-poll violence occurs because the parties get to know how many votes they got from a particular booth but with totaliser use no one will be able to know that. Using totaliser will be in the interest of voters and will help democracy, he submitted.

Referring to a January 2018 SC order, he said that the EC had backed the introduction of totaliser but had changed its views since. The Law Commission too had proposed this, he said.

Appearing for the Commission, Senior Advocate DS Naidu said the Commission had convened an all-party meeting on it. “50% national parties opposed, 68% state-level parties opposed. It was then referred to a Group of Ministers, they also opposed,” he submitted. “On the political front, there is a big

no,” he submitted.

Justice Bagchi said that while totalization was, in principle, a tool for anonymising voter choice, it did not have statutory backing. “The difficulty is... let’s say we pass an order, they will need statutory backing.”

He said that the EC had not said it does not approve the totaliser. “You have pointed out roadblocks in totalisation.”

Naidu said that in the affidavit filed by it, the poll body had pointed out the advantages and difficulties.

Appearing for another petitioner, Senior Advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan said the “only argument of political parties is (that) we as political parties have to go to each polling booth and manage the polling booth”.

He said that “it can’t be the reason (why totaliser should not be implemented), when voters face intimidation and don’t want to be targeted because in that polling booth all of you have voted for party A as against party B. This is to protect voters which is why the Law Commission and the EC and the ministry itself in 2010 had recommended this”.

Naidu submitted that the EC can only recommend, and it is up to the Central government to make the rules in consultation with the EC. Justice Bagchi wondered if it cannot be used “in a situation where there is a perceptible ground reality of victimisation”. Naidu said the Law Commission had said “use it selectively”.

In its affidavit, the Commission while underlining the absence of a statutory provision to introduce it also pointed out that it would affect the existing audit mechanism built around Form 17C, which deals with the statutory record of votes polled, and is maintained in two parts under the Conduct of Election Rules.

It said that when votes are counted in clusters, any discrepancy in one of the clubbed EVMs “would stand concealed within the aggregate figure”.

SCO declaration: Double standards in fight against terror unacceptable

Member States reaffirm commitment to combat terror, separatism, extremism

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, September 1

STRESSING THAT “double standards” in the fight against terror are unacceptable, leaders at the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) on Tuesday called on the international community to combat terrorism, including the cross-border movement of terrorists.

This is part of the ‘Bishkek Declaration’ adopted by India, Pakistan, Iran, Russia, China and the Central Asian countries in the SCO grouping. The declaration is important since India has always maintained that Pakistan is responsible for cross-border terrorism in the country.

On terrorism, the joint declaration stated: “Member States, reaffirming their firm commitment to combating terrorism, separatism and extremism, emphasise the inadmissibility of attempts to exploit terrorist, separatist, and extremist groups for selfish purposes. They recognize the leading role of sovereign states and their competent authorities in countering terrorist and extremist threats.”

“Member states consider attempts to discredit government bodies and structures of SCO member states unacceptable. They emphasize that such actions are contrary to international law and undermine the principles of sovereign equality of states and non-interference in internal affairs enshrined in the UN Charter.”

“Member States strongly condemn terrorism in all its forms and manifestations, emphasize that ‘double standards’

in the fight against terrorism are unacceptable, and call on the international community to combat terrorism, including the cross-border movement of terrorists, with the UN playing a central role by fully implementing relevant UN Security Council resolutions and the UN Global Counter-Terrorism Strategy in accordance with the UN Charter and the principles of international law, in order to jointly combat all terrorist organizations,” the declaration said.

On the war between US-Israel and Iran, the Bishkek Declaration said: “Member states express deep concern over developments in the Middle East and around Iran. They reiterate the SCO’s previously stated position condemning military strikes on the territory of the Islamic Republic of Iran, which have resulted in numerous civilian casualties and significant damage to the country’s economy.”

“Such actions violate the principles and norms of international law and the UN Charter and create serious risks to international peace, security and stability,” it said.

This is important since India has strong ties with Israel, and the criticism of the US and Israel is not the norm for Delhi.

“Member States express their sincere condolences to the people and Government of the Islamic Republic of Iran on the tragic death of Supreme Leader Seyyed Ali Khamenei, and to the families of the victims,” it said.

It also said, “Member States, reaffirming their support for the sovereignty and territorial integ-



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi on the sidelines of the SCO Summit in Bishkek on Tuesday. ANI

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principles of international law enshrined in the UN Charter and emphasize the need to strengthen its role as a guarantor of international peace and security, sustainable development, and the construction of a representative, democratic, and equitable multipolar world order. They make an increasing contribution to the common efforts to qualitatively improve the global order.” This is also important since Russia has invaded Ukraine, China regularly threatens neighbours, including in the South China Sea and the border standoff with India.

On the West’s criticism of human rights “violations” in China, Russia and Iran among others, the declaration said, “Member States emphasize the indivisibility, interdependence and interrelatedness of all human rights and recall the uni-

Sharif’s office crops out Modi from SCO group photograph

Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif’s office had cropped out Prime Minister Narendra Modi from the group photograph at the SCO leaders’ Summit in Bishkek and posted it on X. Facing backlash on social media, they later restored the original photograph on X. ENS

versal nature of the obligation to respect human rights and fundamental freedoms, oppose the application of “double standards”, particularly in matters of human rights, and oppose interference in the internal affairs of sovereign States.”

Indian officials pointed out that SCO reaffirmed the “idea of One Earth, One Family, One Future” for developing dialogue. This was the catchphrase during the 2023 G20 Summit in Delhi.

“Taking into account the views of member states, they reaffirmed the relevance of initiatives to promote cooperation in building a new type of international relations in the spirit of mutual respect, justice, equality and mutually beneficial cooperation, as well as to develop a shared vision of creating a community with a shared destiny for humanity and developing dialogue on the idea of ‘One Earth, One Family, One Future,’” the Declaration said. They said India’s initiatives in SCO were accepted, as it said, “Strengthening scientific, technical and innovative cooperation through active involvement of young people, and through the regular holding of the SCO Young Scientists Forum.”

EXPRESS special

Sensors to risk maps, J&K draws up shield against floods in the light of Nepal disaster

Arun Sharma
Jammu, September 1

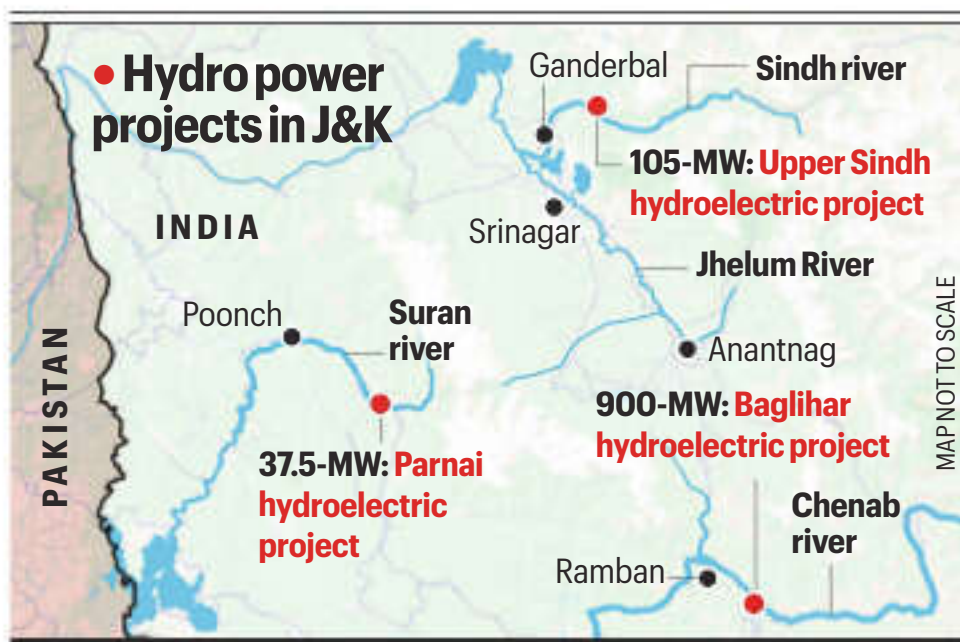
EARLY FLOOD warning systems at three hydroelectric projects, a GIS-based multi-hazard risk atlas, and stronger disaster-risk planning and regulation — these are some of the major measures the Jammu & Kashmir government is planning as part of its early flood warning systems as it considers ways to ensure sufficient response time in the event of a natural disaster.

Rahul Yadav, Managing Director of the Jammu Kashmir Power Development Corporation (JKPDC), told *The Indian Express* that tenders have been floated for installation of these early warning systems at the 900-megawatt (MW) Baglihar hydroelectric project over Chenab river in Ramban district, the 105-MW Upper Sindh hydroelectric project over Sindh river in Ganderbal district, and the 37.5-MW Parnai hydroelectric project built on Suran river near Bafliaz in border Poonch district.

The decision forms part of the UT administration's multi-pronged strategy to strengthen disaster resilience after cloudbursts and floods in J&K, especially in the Chenab Valley region. It assumes significance in view of the large-scale deaths and widespread devastation caused by recent floods in Nepal.

The system will involve identifying strategic locations for installing sensors and communication equipment upstream of dams and barrages, providing 1-2 hours of response time, sources said.

Significantly, all three hydroelectric projects are located in mountainous regions highly vulnerable to flash floods triggered by cloudbursts, avalanches and glacial lake outbursts at high altitudes.



Kishtwar Deputy Commissioner Pankaj Sharma, under whose jurisdiction the Paddar area falls, said that after last year's Chishoti flash floods, several studies were conducted by experts from the Department of Disaster Management, Relief, Rehabilitation and Reconstruction (DMRRR). While the teams initially conducted studies on landslide-prone areas, they later studied GLOFs. Kishtwar, Doda and Ramban districts were placed in the highly vulnerable category for landslides.

As far as high-altitude glacial lakes are concerned, the studies have categorised Mundiskar lake in the district as "highly vulnerable". Sharma said the Kishtwar district administration sent a Rs 35-crore proposal to the DMRRR for disaster mitigation measures nearly a fortnight ago. The work will start once the DMRRR approves the proposal.

Jammu and Kashmir has seen repeated episodes of flash floods, cloudbursts and landslides in recent years, with the Chenab Valley among the worst affected. Since June 1 this year, nearly 35 cloudburst incidents have been reported across the UT, with Kishtwar, Doda and Ramban among the most vul-

nerable districts.

Last year, the Jammu and Kashmir government, quoting a scientific study by researchers from Kashmir University's Department of Geo-informatics, had said that five glacial lakes in the Kashmir Himalayas fall in the "very high susceptibility" class for potential glacial lake outburst floods. Identifying these lakes as Bramsar, Chrisar, Nundgol, Bhagsar and Gangabal, it added, as per the study, their high susceptibility together threatens over 2,700 buildings, 15 key bridges, segments of road infrastructure and one hydroelectric power plant.

Officials said the DMRRR, in a major push to strengthen disaster preparedness in the UT, is implementing a five-pronged strategy across the UT. This includes creating a GIS-based multi-hazard risk atlas using digital terrain and elevation modelling in vulnerable areas, enforcing building safety codes, updating district disaster management plans and integrating risk reduction into master plans.

Apart from establishing a dedicated disaster management training institute, it also intends to sign an MoU with the Geological Survey of India for forecasting landslides.

New Delhi, September 1



Commissioned into the Education Branch of the IAF on June 18, 1994, the senior officer has served across various training establishments, field stations,

The Army and Navy started granting Permanent Commission to women officers in select arms/services and branches in 2008. However, that was extended to other branches in 2020 after the top court's intervention. The fact that only one woman officer (non-medical) has attained the rank of AVM reflects the highly competitive nature of career advancement in the Armed Forces.



Take Bishkek to BRICS

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi's address at the 26th summit of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, comes at a time when Central Asia is diversifying its partnerships in all directions. A region long shaped by its Soviet past and one that still maintains economic links with Russia, its five countries are now also looking to China for trade, investment and infrastructure, and to Iran and the Gulf for access to the south, though the ongoing conflict complicates the latter. The region's growing strategic importance and shared security concerns, including terrorism, have led India and all Central Asian countries except Turkmenistan, which maintains permanent neutrality, to establish strategic partnerships. This evolving context makes the PM's visit even more significant. The PM's speech focused mainly on two issues: Connectivity and terrorism. The absence of direct land access has constrained trade and wider economic and cultural engagement. There is no overland access through Pakistan, and Afghanistan's airspace remains beset by security risks. But connectivity goes far beyond building roads and railways. At its core, it is about shaping the economic and strategic geography of Eurasia. India, therefore, must find ways to expand economic engagement while overcoming the limitations imposed by geography. A starting point could be to focus on products and services that do not depend on roads — services, digital systems and technological investments. On terrorism, the Prime Minister is right to call on the international community to collectively dismantle the ecosystem of terror, including its financing and recruitment networks. The reality New Delhi must recognise, however, is that the international political will against terrorism has weakened. Over the past year, Pakistan has largely overcome its diplomatic isolation, and it is set to assume the organisation's rotational chairmanship. In June last year, SCO defence ministers could not agree on the references to terrorism in their joint statement. China possesses greater financial resources than any other member and is heavily investing in Central Asian infrastructure as part of the Belt and Road Initiative. Delhi should therefore place greater weight on its individual partnerships with member states.

The agreement with Uzbekistan on the long-term supply of uranium is a step in that direction. Central Asian countries are emerging as multi-vector actors. Rather than choosing between competing powers, they are seeking multiple options to improve access to market. India should become one of those options — and use a multilateral forum like the SCO to advance bilateral relationships. That is a strategy New Delhi should carry forward to BRICS, as it prepares to host its 18th summit.

Red label for salt, sugar and fat is a good start

AMID RAPIDLY expanding concerns about Indians' growing consumption of food high in sugar, refined carbohydrates, salt and unhealthy fats comes the FSSAI proposal to implement front-of-pack warnings in the form of red, hexagonal labels on packaged food. Sweetened beverages will carry a separate warning. The proposal comes weeks after the Supreme Court pulled up the apex food regulator for failing to move on warning labels. It is a welcome step towards addressing alarming levels of obesity, particularly among children — India now ranks second globally, after China, for the number of children who are overweight or living with obesity.

Given that eating behaviour is complex and influenced by a number of factors, including gender, economic wherewithal, awareness and faith-based restrictions, there has been scepticism about the effectiveness of food warnings. But there is also evidence that such interventions can change consumption patterns. For example, Chile witnessed a 24 per cent drop in sugary drink consumption after it introduced black octagonal warning labels on packages in 2016. Clarity and legibility are key; a previous FSSAI proposal to use a health star rating system was criticised as such stars are usually perceived as positive and warning labels bearing them have been associated with increased consumption of unhealthy foods.

The notification and timeline for implementation are still awaited. Experts have warned that the two-or-more-unhealthy ingredients threshold in the first of the intended two-phase implementation could leave out products that are high in just one unhealthy ingredient. There are concerns that the proposed font size may be too small to be effective. Warning labels, finally, can only be one part of a larger approach. Addressing the obesity epidemic — which exists alongside malnutrition — will require a broader public-health response that includes raising nutritional awareness, stronger regulation of junk food and nudges towards healthier lifestyles. A red label on a packet may not, by itself, make people eat better, but it is a useful place to start if it makes it easier to tell healthy choices from harmful ones.

MPD-2047 envisages an interconnected Green-Blue network that integrates the Yamuna, the Ridge, forests, biodiversity parks, water bodies, drains, neighbourhood parks, and open spaces into a unified ecological system



TARANJIT SINGH SANDHU

INDIA'S GDP growth of 7.8 per cent in the first quarter once again exceeded expectations, continuing a pattern seen over the past several quarters. Growth surpassed both the median forecast of 6.8 per cent by professional forecasters and the RBI's revised projection of 7 per cent. The outperformance underscores the strength of India's domestic drivers and its ability to navigate an increasingly uncertain global environment.

Even amid continuing conflict in West Asia and weather-related uncertainties, high-frequency indicators had signalled strong momentum. Robust industrial activity, healthy consumption and strong goods exports, alongside accelerating government investment, were the key drivers of growth in the first quarter of this fiscal.

The residual impact of policy measures introduced last fiscal year, coupled with continued support through direct benefit transfers, also bolstered growth. Such programmes have expanded steadily, with 17 states now providing cash transfers, primarily to women. The impact of GST rate cuts was particularly visible in automobiles. Dealer discounts and higher disposable incomes resulting from income-tax relief provided additional support. According to data from the SIAM, sales of passenger vehicles, commercial vehicles and two-wheelers rose 26 per cent, 20.3 per cent and 18.3 per cent respectively in the first quarter.

Retail credit growth remained robust with other personal loans, a proxy for short-term consumption, growing at 14.2 per cent. Also, households were cushioned against the sharp rise in crude prices with government

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and oil companies absorbing most of it, particularly in the initial phase of conflict.

That said, as 2026-27 progresses, the growth-inflation mix is likely to become less favourable, with growth moderating and inflation rising. Crisil expects GDP growth of 7 per cent and inflation of 5.1 per cent.

The moderation in growth reflects a more challenging external environment, marked by disruptions from the conflict in West Asia, unresolved tariff issues with the US, weather-related risks and a strong base effect in the second half. The two exogenous factors that worked in India's favour last year, low crude oil prices and a normal monsoon, are unlikely to provide similar support this year.

Meanwhile, the conflict in West Asia has disrupted supply chains, increased insurance, freight and input costs, and is likely to weigh on both global and domestic growth.

Weather-related risks warrant close monitoring as El Niño conditions in the equatorial Pacific intensify. Over the past 25 years, five of the six El Niño years have resulted in below-normal rainfall. This year, cumulative rainfall was 14 per cent below the long-period average (LPA) at the end of August. While rainfall in July was 1 per cent above the LPA, August recorded a deficit of 16 per cent. The IMD has signalled below-normal rainfall in September.

There are, however, some mitigating factors. India's net irrigated area has risen by 10 percentage points to 59 per cent over the past decade, improving resilience to rainfall shocks. The country also holds ample rice and



DHARMAKIRTI JOSHI

As 2026-27 progresses, the growth-inflation mix is likely to become less favourable, with growth moderating and inflation rising. Crisil expects GDP growth of 7 per cent and inflation of 5.1 per cent

The writer is Lieutenant Governor, Delhi

wheat stocks, which should help contain food price pressures.

Agriculture itself is becoming more resilient as non-crop activities gain a larger share. While crop gross value added contracted by an average 0.5 per cent annually in the five years to 2023-24, non-crop agriculture, which now accounts for nearly 40 per cent of agricultural gross value added, expanded 6.5 per cent annually. Nor is the relationship between monsoons and inflation straightforward. Historical evidence suggests deficient monsoons do not always lead to higher food inflation. Foodgrain stocks, currently more than twice buffer norms, provide an additional cushion against price spikes.

Even so, these improvements do not fully insulate agriculture or the broader economy. Several crops without buffer stocks, as well as perishable vegetables, remain vulnerable to adverse weather. Weak monsoons can also hurt rabi production by reducing soil moisture and lowering reservoir levels. Agricultural output and food inflation therefore remain key variables to watch.

Although headline inflation eased in July and core inflation remained benign, upside risks persist. Our base case assumes Brent crude prices averaging \$82-87 per barrel this fiscal. The unresolved conflict in West Asia continues to keep oil prices volatile. Higher crude prices typically translate into slower growth, higher inflation and a wider current account deficit.

Core inflation, often viewed as a gauge of underlying demand pressures, also appears decep-

tively low. Strong demand conditions, rising fuel costs and other input pressures, reflected in near-double-digit wholesale price inflation, are gradually being passed through to consumers.

The automobile sector illustrates this well. Vehicle prices are likely to rise as manufacturers pass on higher costs to protect margins, while dealer discounts are gradually withdrawn. Combined with a high base effect, this should moderate automobile growth in the second half.

Unlike last year, the balance of risks now points towards possible interest rate hikes. Persistent inflationary pressures, coupled with an unresolved conflict in West Asia and weather-related risks, could bring monetary tightening back into consideration.

Despite the expected moderation in growth, India's macroeconomic buffers remain strong. Foreign exchange reserves cover more than nine months of imports, while corporate and banking-sector balance sheets are in robust health. The economy remains resilient, but the road ahead is likely to be less forgiving than last year. The challenge will be to sustain high growth in an increasingly uncertain global environment.

For now, tax relief and public investment continue to support activity. The Pay Commission's recommendations should provide an additional boost to consumption when implemented. Beyond cyclical tailwinds, sustained progress on structural reforms that enhance competitiveness will be critical to maintaining the growth momentum.

Joshi is chief economist, Crisil Ltd

Solution for stubble burning lies close to the farm



SHWETA SAINI



GOPAL SOOD

IN A few weeks, Delhi will again begin watching Punjab's farm fires. Governments will announce measures and farmers will again be asked not to burn paddy straw. But the economics facing farmers has changed little over the years: Bulky residue, a narrow window before wheat sowing, and a cost attached to almost every alternative to burning.

What has changed, however, is the value of parali itself. When we began working on crop residues, farmers in several locations were still paying to have straw removed. Today, in parts of Punjab, the same straw can fetch around Rs 1.5-2 per kg. Demand from power plants, CBG units and pellet manufacturers is slowly creating a market for what was until recently treated as waste.

This raises another question: If parali now has value, where should that value be created, and how much can remain with the farmer? Biochar offers one possibility. It is a carbon-rich material produced by heating biomass under limited oxygen, and can be made from crop residues such as paddy, maize, cotton and mustard stalks. Roughly 100 kg of dry parali can yield around 30 kg of char. Applied to soil, it can improve water retention and nutrient-use efficiency, while locking carbon away for a century.

This differs from using biomass only as fuel. Burning recovers energy but returns much of its carbon to the atmosphere. Biochar applied to soil can retain a significant share while also serving an agronomic purpose. For Punjab, this matters. Its rice-wheat system is under stress from declining soil quality, intensive fertiliser use, and groundwater depletion. Residue generated by the same system could improve its soils. The problem is where processing happens. Parali has to be collected, baled, stored and transported within the narrow window before wheat sowing. Long-distance transport of a bulky, relatively low-value material quickly eats into its economics. The farmer supplies raw material, while much value-addition happens after biomass leaves the village.

With biochar, the irony is greater. A farmer may supply the straw, see it processed elsewhere and later buy back a product made from biomass originating on farms like his. Why not, then, move the technology closer to the straw? India already understands decentralised rural processing. Wheat does not travel 100 km merely because flour requires machinery. The village chakki places processing close to where the commodity is produced and consumed. Paddy residue may need a similar rethink.

We have been developing a village-scale biochar system around a build-operate-transfer model. A technology provider initially installs and operates the unit, trains local operators and ensures quality and emission standards. Over time, the asset and capability can transfer to an FPO, SHG, or cooperative.

The government does not need to run thousands of such units. It can provide standards, training, concessional finance and initial support. Panchayats can help with land and coordination. Farmers could bring straw to a nearby processing point much as they bring wheat to a flour mill. Some biochar could return to their fields; the rest could be sold where markets exist. This changes the economics. Raw straw travels less, value addition happens closer to the farmer, and villages are not left with subsidised machinery nobody knows how to operate. It also changes the incentive to burn. Burning remains quick and cheap where alternatives involve cost, labour and uncertainty. Enforcement and machinery subsidies can help, but behaviour is likely to change when residue itself becomes valuable. As biomass markets develop, the question should be: Where should value from parali be created, and who should capture it? The answer may lie closer to the farm.

Saini is CEO, Arcus Policy Research. Sood is chairperson, Arcus Serves Foundation

Wheat does not travel 100 km merely because flour requires machinery. The village chakki places processing close to where the commodity is produced and consumed. Paddy residue may need a similar rethink

China, US are in race to connect science with industry. India must catch up



RAJA MANDALA
BY C RAJA MOHAN

BEHIND THE riot of robots running, dancing and playing at Beijing's second World Humanoid Games last week is an ambitious Chinese project to turn China into the world's leading science power. This ambition is rooted in President Xi Jinping's call to fully mobilise "new quality productive forces" being unleashed by the current revolutions in science and technology. Xi is convinced that China's next phase of growth cannot rely on cheap labour, large-scale manufacturing, infrastructure and capital accumulation. It must come from innovation.

AI is central to Xi's strategy. Beijing's objective is to diffuse AI across the physical economy — robotics, machine tools, automobiles, biotechnology, materials, energy, agriculture and scientific research. China's manufacturing depth is its advantage. Beijing is betting that fusing digital intelligence with the world's largest industrial ecosystem will make China the leading technological power.

For decades, China absorbed foreign technology, improved it through manufacturing and dominated production. It now wants to move upstream — from adaptation to original discovery. China spent 2.8 per cent of GDP on R&D in 2025; basic-research expenditure rose by 11 per cent. The manufacturing power now seeks to become a science superpower.

The logic is simple: AI accelerates discovery; discovery produces technology; technology transforms industry; industrial strength generates national power and gives China a geopolitical edge.

Washington is reaching a similar conclusion, coming from the opposite direction. The Trump administration's Science: A New Golden Age, released in July, has been billed as the first major reset in US science policy since World War II. It begins by recognising Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

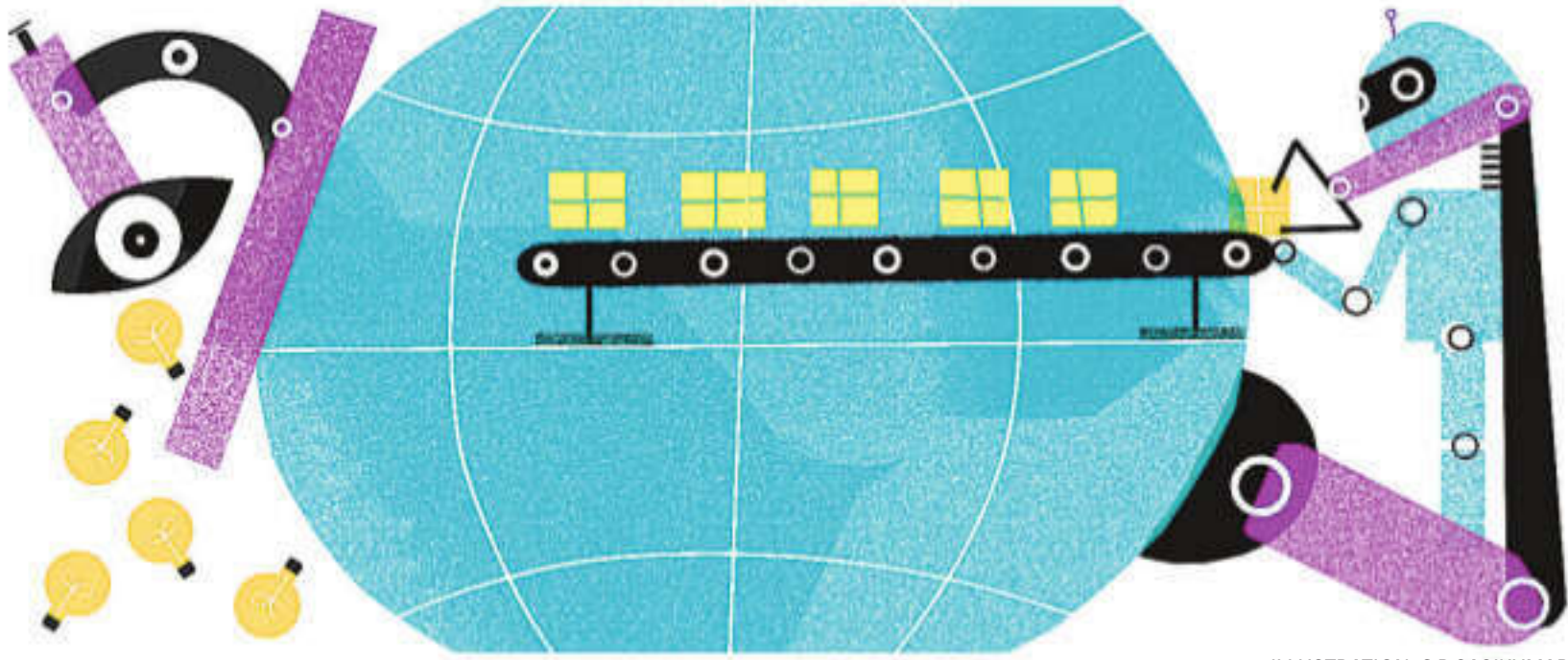


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

American strengths — its great universities, laboratories, technology companies and capital markets. It also acknowledges the American weakness — the erosion of the capacity to turn discoveries into production.

Globalisation separated American innovation from manufacturing. Companies designed at home, produced abroad and depended on long supply chains. That model generated wealth but also vulnerabilities exposed by the pandemic, China's rise and geopolitical rivalry. Washington now wants to reintegrate the production of knowledge and manufacturing.

Washington and Beijing see AI not merely as a general-purpose technology, but as an accelerator central to the production of new knowledge that in turn will transform industry. By making discovery continuous with design and manufacturing, AI-driven science will transform production itself — and turn scientific speed into economic power and geopolitical capability.

China begins with the largest manufacturing base and moves upstream into science. America begins with the strongest scientific system and moves downstream into manufacturing. China fears dependence on American technology; the US fears dependence on Chinese production. Both seek to close the gap between knowledge and production.

This contest is not about who unveils the cleverest AI model or the most sophisticated humanoid. It is about building the most effective ecosystem connecting universities, laboratories, entrepreneurs, finance, energy, factories, supply chains and markets

This contest is not about who unveils the cleverest AI model. It is about building the most effective ecosystem connecting universities, laboratories, entrepreneurs, finance, energy, factories, supply chains and markets



SYED ATA HASNAIN

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi's presence at the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit comes at an unusually consequential moment. The war in Ukraine continues, the Gulf has been shaken by the US-Israeli conflict with Iran, and the international system is searching for a new equilibrium. Hence, the significance of this SCO lies most in who is sitting around the table. PM Modi is there with Russia's President Vladimir Putin, Chinese President Xi Jinping, Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian and the leaders of Central Asia. This is precisely where India needs to be.

The SCO has never been an entirely comfortable strategic space for India. Yet it is important. The PM's bilateral engagement with Putin covered defence, energy, economic cooperation and the consequences of conflicts in West Asia and the Black Sea for maritime trade. Xi's presence is equally consequential even without a formal bilateral meeting. India and China are major economies and neighbours whose interests intersect across Asia. This is strategic autonomy in practice: The ability to engage Washington, Moscow and Beijing without allowing any one relationship to determine the others.

What makes this summit different is Iran. The conflict has shown how rapidly a West Asian crisis can acquire Eurasian consequences. The PM's meeting with President

That is why Bishkek matters beyond the SCO communiqué. The PM's presence signals that India intends to remain fully engaged wherever Eurasia's future is being shaped

In Bishkek, a lesson from Nalanda

Pezeshkian carried significance beyond bilateral ties. India emphasised diplomacy, protection of civilians and freedom of navigation and commerce. For India, Iran is also a geography. Pakistan denies India overland access to Central Asia. Afghanistan remains uncertain. Iran is vital to projects such as Chabahar and the International North-South Transport Corridor. After the Gulf crisis, West Asia and Central Asia can no longer be viewed as distinct strategic theatres.

Washington will examine Bishkek for signs of something larger: Whether China, Russia and Iran can transform dissatisfaction with the international order into durable institutional cooperation; whether alternative financial and connectivity structures acquire momentum; and where India positions itself. It would be mistaken, however, to interpret India's presence as evidence of an emerging anti-Western alignment. Its interests are more complex.

The Central Asian republics understand this. They have relationships with Russia, growing economic engagement with China, and seek wider partnerships with other countries. This is an opportunity for India. I was in Kyrgyzstan in June for the Issyk-Kul International Forum. Before that, I received the SCO Secretary General in Patna. These interactions reinforced that Central Asia desires to rediscover the region's ci-

at \$75 billion in purchasing-power-adjusted dollars, against \$786 billion for China and \$782 billion for the United States. In nominal dollar terms, India will look even less impressive.

Second, India has not reformed its scientific institutions. China's reform era launched in the late 1970s by Deng Xiaoping put the revitalisation of science and technology at the heart of his Four Modernisations. India's reform era, beginning in the 1990s, produced no comparable overhaul.

India and China both benefited from access to American universities that offered valuable training in advanced sciences for their vast talent pools. China combined that opportunity with massive domestic investment in science and higher education and incentives for researchers to return. To say that India's science sector does not attract talent back is an understatement.

If the Congress era saw the steady bureaucratisation of Indian science, the BJP is adding cultural nationalism to it. Civilisational pride cannot make mythology a substitute for evidence, experiment and scientific temper. India's most confident claim should not be that all modern science was discovered in its past, but that the greatest Indian contributions lie in the future.

Equally unfortunate is the Indian tendency to talk tall. Delhi's radical posturing on technological "self-reliance" in the 1970s and 1980s isolated India from global technological advances. Today, again, there is grandiose talk of "technological sovereignty". India must necessarily walk on two legs: Deepen cooperation with global science, capital, technology and talent while building domestic research, industrial and institutional capacity.

Without reform of the state-led science system and a massive commitment from private capital, Indian industry could well become a subaltern to Chinese and American science-industrial systems that are set to become as breathtaking as the robots we saw in Beijing last week.

The writer is contributing editor on international affairs for The Indian Express. He is a distinguished professor at the Motwani Jadeja Institute of American Studies, Jindal Global University and holds the Korea Foundation Chair on Asian Geopolitics at the Council for Strategic and Defence Research, Delhi

vilisational importance. This offers India an advantage: Centuries of civilisational familiarity without a memory of domination. At Issyk-Kul, I spoke of what we in Bihar have begun describing as the Nalanda Approach. Ancient Nalanda was a knowledge ecosystem linking scholars and civilisations across Asia. That principle can acquire contemporary meaning through university partnerships, joint research, scholar exchanges, historical studies, technology collaboration and sustained intellectual dialogue.

India and Central Asia are geographically close but strategically separated. The absence of direct land access has constrained commerce, tourism, academic exchange and human interaction. Chabahar, the INSTC, air connectivity and new multimodal arrangements deserve greater attention.

That is why Bishkek matters beyond the SCO communiqué. The PM's presence signals that India intends to remain fully engaged wherever Eurasia's future is being shaped. Strategic partnerships can secure India a place at the table, and connectivity can give those partnerships substance. India has the ability to reconnect with Central Asia through knowledge, culture and civilisational memory. In a world once again dominated by contests for power, that may prove to be a remarkably durable form of influence.

The writer is Governor of Bihar



SHASHANK R JOSHI

ON OCTOBER 3, 2023, South Lhonak Lake in Sikkim burst. A wall of water and debris tore down the Teesta. Homes vanished. Official tallies put the dead at over 50; dozens more were never found. The flood held the front page for two days. What did not hold the front page was the young man in Teesta Bazaar who lost his house, his insulin, and his mother's medical records. The flood receded. But for six months after the cameras left, the real disaster was a cold chain that never returned, a prescription that could not be refilled, and a health system that had been counted as infrastructure, not as life.

We have framed glacier retreat as a cli-

Himalayan disaster redraws disease ecology

mate change-related issue. After the latest disaster in Nepal, it is time to look at it from a health perspective. We know what happens when the water arrives. We still barely speak about what happens after it leaves.

Four waves of harm. Wave One: The immediate kill. Drowning, trauma, hypothermia. Kedamath 2013, Chamoli 2021, Sikkim 2023 — deaths were counted. Injuries were not. Crush wounds. Fractures. Frostbite.

Wave Two: The contamination. Glacial silt plus sewage plus animal carcasses is a laboratory for acute diarrhoea, hepatitis A and E, typhoid, skin infections and leptospirosis. When the primary health centre goes under, a pregnant woman delivers on the roadside. Vaccines warm. The outbreak begins after the rescue teams leave.

Wave Three: The invisible disruption. This is the largest wave, and the least

counted. Himalayan states carry a heavy load of non-communicable disease. A disaster like that in Nepal snaps the drug chain. Insulin needs refrigeration; electricity may be out for weeks. Dialysis patients are forced onto journeys of hundreds of kilometres, and tuberculosis treatment is interrupted.

Wave Four: The long shadow. After the Sikkim disaster, clinicians reported old patients relapsing and new ones arriving with

A disaster like that in Nepal snaps the drug chain. Insulin needs refrigeration; electricity may be out for weeks. Dialysis patients are forced onto journeys of hundreds of kilometres

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panic, hyperarousal and the inability to sleep when rain begins. Children stop going to school. Farmers watch a field turn into a stone bed. In the wetlands the flood leaves behind, mosquitoes appear at altitudes where they were never a public-health concern. The glacier redraws disease ecology.

Preparedness needs to be rewritten from a health perspective. First, map the downstream health footprint. ISRO and NDMA already rank dangerous water bodies. Overlay that map with Health and Family Welfare data: Primary health centres, sub-centres, cold-chain points, antenatal caseloads, insulin-dependent patients, dialysis chairs. Second, treat early warning as a clinical intervention — to lift an oxygen plant, move vaccines, shift women in labour, and lock the NCD cupboard onto higher ground. Third, make the hill hospital climate-proof. The Na-

tional Programme on Climate Change and Human Health must name glacier-related disasters as a core hazard for Himalayan districts. Every district hospital in those catchments needs elevated drug storage, a solar-backed cold chain, a seven-day emergency kit for hypertension, diabetes, asthma and mental-health first aid, and household safe-water stock. Fourth, watch for 90 days, not 90 hours. Post-disaster, surveillance should be syndromic: Diarrhoea, jaundice, wound infections, breathlessness, distress and new-onset fever where vectors have new water.

The next glacier tragedy will ask whether anyone counted the insulin, the dialysis chair, the labour room and the child who still starbles when the river rises in a dream.

The writer is an endocrinologist and public health physician based in Mumbai

OIL IMPORTS FROM VENEZUELA JUMPED 60.2% IN AUGUST

Russian oil imports fell 26% in Aug amid supply pressure, China factor

India's total oil imports in August stood at 4.62 million bpd, down 8.4% from July's 5.04 million bpd

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, September 1

INDIA'S OIL imports from Russia in August declined 26% from the historic highs in the previous month amid tighter Russian export availability as well as stronger competition from Chinese refiners, according to provisional tanker data.

Maintenance shutdowns at a few Indian refineries also likely contributed to lower crude intake.

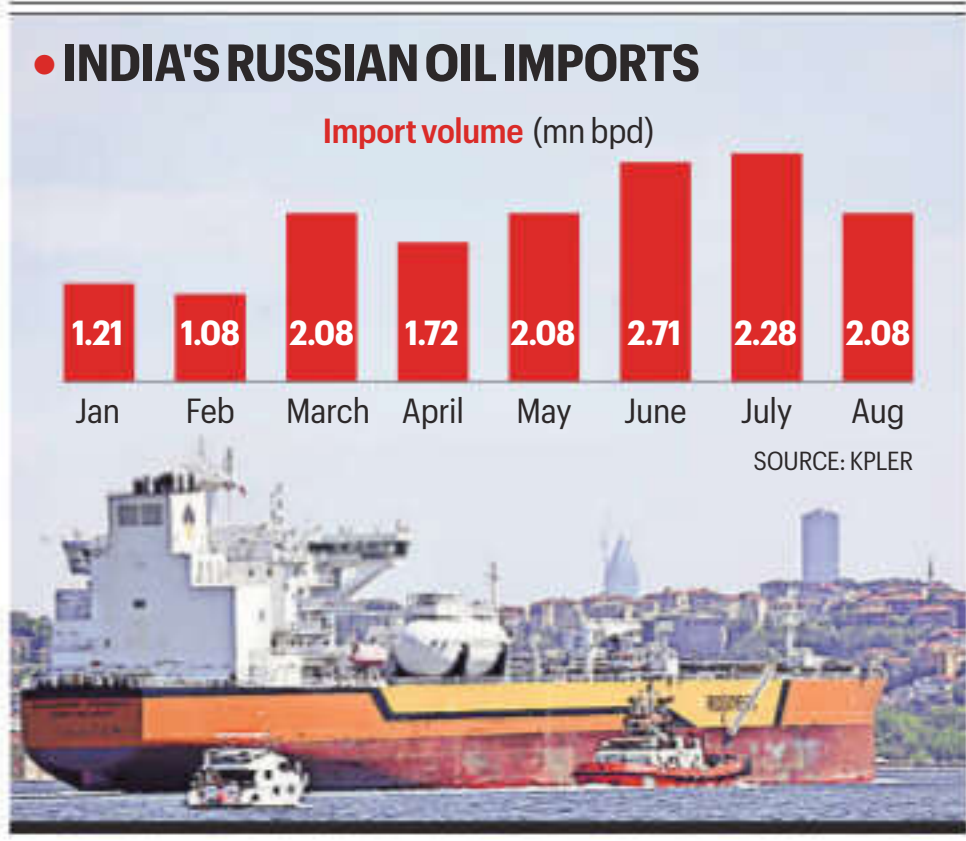
The fall in Russian volumes was the primary reason for the over 8% decline in India's overall oil imports in August. Notably, though, oil imports from Venezuela touched their highest monthly levels since 2020. With the US allowing Caracas's oil to flow into the global market, India restarted imports of Venezuelan oil a few months ago after nearly a year of zero imports.

According to vessel tracking data from commodity market analytics firm Kpler, India imported 2.08 million barrels per day (bpd) of Russian oil in August, down 26.3% from July's record levels of 2.82 million bpd.

India's total oil imports in

August stood at 4.62 million bpd, down 8.4% from July's 5.04 million bpd. Moscow's share in New Delhi's crude diet declined to 45% in August from 55.9% in July. According to Kpler, the shift points to market normalisation rather than a structural retreat from Russian crude, with flows expected to stabilise at 2.0 to 2.5 million bpd in the foreseeable future, which suggests that Russian oil is likely to remain the mainstay of India's oil imports. The import volumes, however, may come under some pressure due to the evolving energy market conditions with Russia's ability to export more being constrained and intensifying competition for Russian barrels from China.

"Russia is exporting less crude both to India and overall, just as China is competing more aggressively for available cargoes. The question for the coming months is therefore whether August represents a temporary retreat or the start of a period in which Russian barrels become scarcer, costlier and harder for Indian refiners to secure," said Abu Dhabi-based energy ana-



lyst Natalia Katona. Ukrainian attacks on Russia's oil and gas infrastructure is a key reason for the pressure on Russian oil exports. Attacks on export infrastructure in the Black Sea have become a tangible threat to navigation of energy tankers in the region.

Freight economics are incentivising avoiding the Black Sea routes altogether, according to Katona. For instance, moving a Suezmax tanker from the Black Sea port of Novorossiysk to India's west coast now costs about \$20 million, or roughly \$20 per barrel, compared with about \$13 per barrel if the tanker starts from the Baltic Sea ports. But dispatches from the Baltic Sea

ports carry their own risks, as Russian tankers sailing around Europe face detention or seizure by European countries.

"That has encouraged greater use of the Northern Sea Route (NSR), for which August and September are the peak traffic months even in a normal year due to the thin ice levels. With Black Sea drone threats adding to the pressure, Russian exporters are sending more vessels through the route, logically making China the most competitive destination," Katona said.

Competition for Russian oil from China has picked up due to a few more factors, which in-

clude lower Russian oil exports as Moscow has been trying to maximise domestic refinery production to meet domestic fuel demand amid Ukrainian attacks on its energy infrastructure, and the fall in Iranian oil volumes available to Chinese refiners amid the Strait of Hormuz crisis.

India's crude import strategy has shifted sharply since March 2026 as Strait of Hormuz disruptions tightened West Asian oil flows and increased freight risks. Russian crude remains the backbone of India's import slate, while refiners have diversified aggressively towards African, North American, and South American barrels to offset the drop in supplies from the Gulf.

Interestingly, oil imports from Venezuela in August jumped 60.2% over July to 350,000 bpd, the Kpler data shows. With the US capturing Venezuela's then president Nicolás Maduro early January, Trump had said that Washington would take control of Caracas's oil sector. After that, a few commodity traders were authorised by Washington to sell Venezuelan oil globally, which had been under US sanctions.

About 40% of India's crude imports usually came through the Strait of Hormuz, and a large part of that supply has effectively been offline.

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FOREIGN ASSETS DISCLOSURE SCHEME

Concerns rise over high fee on ESOPs, small investments

Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, September 1

● *A salaried individual had invested Rs 90,000 in stocks listed in the US, now trading at a loss. The money transfer was part of the annual information statement (AIS) of the person's income tax return (ITR) but he did not disclose it separately in the Schedule FA (foreign assets). Under the new scheme, he will have to pay Rs 1 lakh upfront for disclosing the loss-making investment.*

● *An employee with a foreign company operating in India had the vesting details of his employee stock ownership plan (ESOP) as part of his salary, but had not declared it separately in the Schedule FA. He has to now pay Rs 1 lakh just as disclosure charges under the new scheme.*

When the government proposed the foreign assets disclosure scheme in this year's Budget, the intent was well specified — to address "practical issues of small taxpayers like students, young professionals, tech employees, relocated NRIs" among others.

However, the disclosure window, Foreign Assets of Small Taxpayers – Disclosure Scheme (FAST-DS), launched on August 16, has now resulted in doubts and questions as individuals face high fees and penalties. The problem is more acute for salaried individuals who have received restricted stock units (RSUs) or ESOPs, and not reported them before. Even for cases where there has not been any actual gain, the employees will now be required to pay Rs 1 lakh for disclosure under the scheme,

which is being seen as too steep an amount by many. "The ESOPs are part of my salary, just that I did not disclose it separately earlier. Asking for Rs 1 lakh as an amount for only disclosure is too high," the employee with the foreign company cited above said.

Change in status

Experts said that the change in status from a non-resident to an Indian resident needs to be taken note of by the authorities, especially for cases where salaried employees took ESOPs from their global companies. "Many of them were non-resident Indians (NRIs) then and were later deputed to India and became Indian residents. They did not disclose the old details earlier and are disclosing it now. After disclosure, you get the notices saying how did you acquire it? The NRIs have turned into residents, that has to be taken note of," a top executive with an asset management company said.

ESOPs are key salary components in many sectors, especially in tech sector, startups and foreign companies. The scale of ESOPs in India's net outflows can be seen from the sharp rise of the flows under "financial derivatives (other than reserves) and employee stock options" of the Balance of Payments (BoP) in recent years. In 2025-26, this figure stood at just under \$24 billion, up 8% from a net outflow of around \$22 billion in 2024-25. However, it rose sharply in 2024-25, almost tripling from nearly \$8 billion in 2023-24. Many employees are considering filing an up-

dated return for such anomalies rather than disclosing under the scheme, with greater scrutiny going ahead being one of the key concerns. When asked, tax officials pointed out that the Black Money (Undisclosed Foreign Income and Assets) and Imposition of Tax Act doesn't recognise updated returns for income that was never before taxed or disclosed. "So even if the updated return is filed, he'll still be liable to tax and penalty under the Black Money Act. That's why it is better to disclose under FAST-DS. There is no intention of more scrutiny for such declarations," an income tax official said.

'Disproportionate penalty'

The scheme has two categories: i) undisclosed and never-before-taxed foreign income or asset outside India up to Rs 1 crore; ii) asset up to Rs 5 crore outside India, which was already offered to tax or was acquired under non-resident status, but not declared properly in the ITR. Under the first category, an assessee needs to pay 30% of fair market value of assets or undisclosed income as tax and 30% as additional income tax in lieu of penalty, while for the second category, the disclosure fee is Rs 1 lakh. The question is also of materiality — the maximum amount of error allowed in the financial statements before they are considered wrong. Experts pointed out that if the amounts are not significant enough, the penalty of Rs 1 lakh looks disproportionate.

After Q1 surprise, economists hike FY27 GDP growth outlook

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, September 1

THE RESERVE Bank of India's (RBI) GDP growth forecast of 6.7% for 2026-27, made on August 5, is looking increasingly conservative, with economists making sharp upward revisions to their predictions after Monday's blockbuster 7.8% growth print for April-June.

Ranging from 20 basis points to 80 basis points (bps), the growth upgrades made by economists on Monday and Tuesday have been such that the consensus number is now 7.2%, up from 6.7% earlier, according to estimates of 10 economists. Their forecasts are now in the range of 6.9-7.5%.

GDP growth has been higher than 7% in the last three years: 7.3% in 2023-24, 7.2% in 2024-25, and 7.8% in 2025-26. A full-year growth print of over 7% in 2026-27 would make it four years in a row.

According to ANZ economists Dhiraj Nim and Sanjay Mathur, the April-June growth number "marked the 12th consecutive quarter of positive surprise relative to market expectations". While the RBI had forecast 7%, market economists were closer to 7.3-7.5%, with only a small number predicting that growth could be as high as 7.8-8%. However, even those who predicted such a high number have made a sharp upward revision to their forecast for 2026-27 as a whole. Soumya Kanti Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

Ghosh, State Bank of India's Group Chief Economic Adviser, has raised his forecast by 70 bps to 7.3%, having predicted that growth may come in at 8% in April-June. "GDP growth has continued to surprise on the upside," said Upasana Chachra and Bani Gambhir, economists at Morgan Stanley, in a note. According to them, the strength in manufacturing and investment activity "aligns with our view of India being on the cusp of a capex up-cycle".

"The stronger-than-expected April-June data, alongside the robust tracking data for July-September so far, point to sustained growth momentum. Against this backdrop, we raise our FY27 real GDP growth forecast to 7.3% (from 6.7%)," they said. Those who didn't raise their growth forecasts admitted there is an upside risk to their predictions. However, some chose to keep their powder dry keeping in mind an expected slowdown in the second half of the year and the risks to the growth outlook.

For instance, ICICI Securities Primary Dealership's economists led by A Prasanna — who retained their forecast of 7% — see five risk factors for growth in the next three quarters: an unfavourable base effect, crude oil prices, any impact on agriculture growth and rural demand from sub-par rains, and the hit to India's exports from weaker foreign demand due to tighter financial conditions.

In the same vein, they expect the RBI to also consider interest rate hikes, as signalled by the central bank's officials in the minutes of the Monetary Policy Committee's August 3-5 meeting.

"Fiscal policy choices will also be crucial. In case the government chooses to stick to the fiscal deficit target, and given the front loading on the capex growth front, there could be marginal headwind to demand from that side as well," they added. As per the RBI's own forecast, GDP growth is seen at 6.4% in July-September, 6.5% in October-December, 6.8% in January-March 2027, and 7.3% in April-June 2027. The RBI's MPC will next meet October 5-7, where the central bank is expected to raise its own prediction of growth this year.

"The strong GDP data should bolster the MPC's confidence on growth, and sharpen its focus on inflation," Nomura's Sonal Varma and Aurodeep Nandi said.

"The key question is whether stronger growth will lead to more demand side inflationary pressures — which have been absent thus far, despite the surge in input costs."

Data released earlier this month showed headline retail inflation inched up to 4.45% in July from 4.38% in June — the second month in a row it was above the RBI's medium-term target of 4%. FULL REPORT ON

WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Current account deficit widens to \$4.2 bn in Q1

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, September 1

INDIA'S CURRENT account deficit (CAD) widened to \$4.2 billion, or 0.5% of GDP, in the first quarter of 2026-27, from \$3.4 billion, or 0.4% of GDP in the corresponding quarter a year ago, according to data released by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI).

The modest widening in the CAD came primarily on the back of a sharper merchandise trade deficit. The merchandise trade gap increased to \$86.1 billion in Q1 2026-27, compared with \$68.9 billion in Q1 2025-26, reflecting the continued pressure from India's import bill, the central bank said.

However, the impact of the wider trade deficit was partly offset by stronger earnings from services and higher remittance receipts.

Net services receipts rose to \$51.6 billion during the quarter from \$47.9 billion a year earlier. Services exports increased year-on-year across major segments, including computer services, other business services and transportation services, the RBI said.

The primary income account also provided some relief. Net outgo on the account, which largely reflects investment income payments, declined to \$10.5 billion in Q1 2026-27 from \$13.3 billion in the year-ago quarter, it said.

● THE OPERATIONAL FRAMEWORK NOTIFIED ON MONDAY PUTS CHIP DESIGN AT THE FRONT OF THE NEW SEMICONDUCTOR MISSION

Semicon 2.0: How India aims to build a domestic chip design ecosystem

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, September 1

THE CENTRE'S Rs 1.27 lakh crore Semicon 2.0 programme has laid out a three-part push to build domestic chip-design companies, offering government-backed support for developing strategic semiconductor technologies, commercially viable chips, and getting those products deployed in the market.

The operational framework notified Monday puts chip design at the front of the new semiconductor mission.

Of the programme's six pillars and 10 categories, its first pillar is entirely focused on design, with separate tracks for chips required for national and strategic priorities, commercial

semiconductor products, and a deployment-linked incentive for newly developed chips.

The design push seeks to address a key gap in India's semiconductor ambitions. While the country has emerged as a major global base for chip-design engineers, much of this work is currently done for multinational semiconductor companies.

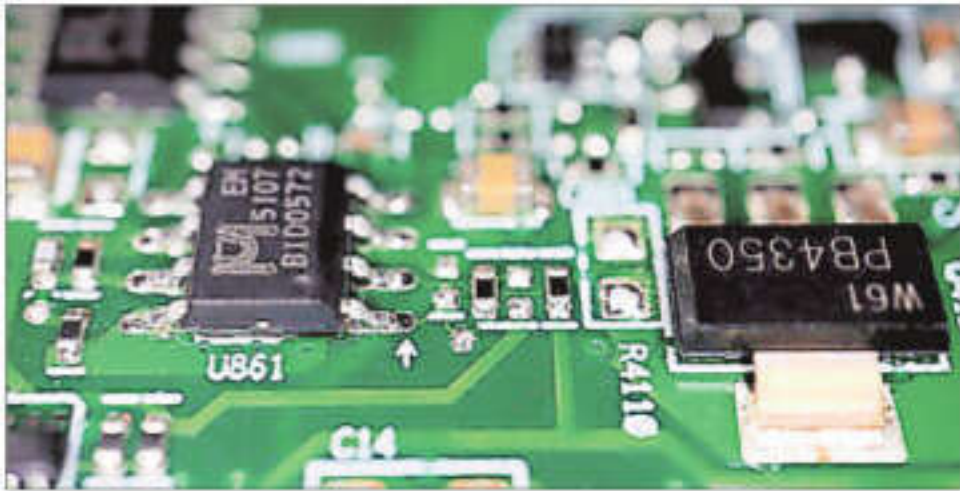
Semicon 2.0 seeks to build more Indian-owned intellectual property and fabless semiconductor companies — firms that design and sell chips while outsourcing their physical fabrication.

Boosting chip design

The first track is aimed at semiconductor technologies

considered important for national security and critical infrastructure. The government will identify IP, chips, systems-on-chip (SoCs) and modules that it wants developed, including building blocks for compute, memory, radio frequency, power, networking and sensors. A second track is meant for commercial chip-design companies.

Here, the government will provide access to expensive electronic design automation tools, multi-project wafer fabrication services, IP cores, compute subsystems and post-silicon validation facilities. Start-ups and MSMEs can receive milestone-linked seed funding of up to Rs 15 crore, or 50% of the project cost,



The design push seeks to address a key gap in India's semiconductor ambitions. REUTERS
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which ever is lower. The government can also make equity co-investments alongside venture capital and private equity investors. Larger eligible companies can opt for royalty financing, under which they will pay 5% of the net revenue from

provided they are incorporated and headquartered in India and maintain a significant operational and manpower presence here. The IP and associated design and development files will have to remain in India.

"I was also glad to see that the scheme has this time been opened up to companies owned by Overseas Citizens of India which is a very good decision, since they bring rich global experience that will help create truly advanced design companies in India," said Arjun Malhotra, co-founder of HCL and chairperson of the EPIC Foundation.

Helping Indian chips find buyers

Semicon 2.0 also intro-

duces a separate deployment-linked incentive, aimed at the next problem after successfully designing a chip: getting customers to adopt it at scale.

Eligible semiconductor IP, chips and SoCs launched after the scheme's announcement will receive a reimbursement equivalent to 9% of their net sales for five years.

The benefit is capped at Rs 30 crore per application and Rs 120 crore for a company, including its group entities, across multiple products. This is particularly relevant for young fabless companies, which can face a hurdle convincing electronics manufacturers to switch from established overseas semiconductor suppliers to a newly developed Indian chip.

Broader ecosystem

The scheme is also aimed at filling gaps across the semiconductor supply chain. Companies setting up semiconductor equipment R&D facilities, plants manufacturing wafers, photomasks, photoresists, substrates, chemicals and gases, testing facilities, or units producing semiconductor equipment and components can receive 30% capital expenditure support. Equipment manufacturers will additionally get a production-linked incentive that declines from 10% to 2% over five years on the value of their bill of materials sourced domestically. Large silicon wafer fabs will be eligible for 40% capex support.

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• DEFENCE

INS Nipun: Key boost to India's deep-sea abilities



The INS Nipun diving support vessel. x/@INDIANNAVY

Sushant Kulkarni
Pune, September 1

THE INDIAN Navy commissioned INS Nipun, the second diving support vessel (DSV) of the Nistar class, in Mumbai on Monday. The vessel will strengthen the Western Naval Command's deep-sea diving, underwater intervention and submarine rescue capabilities.

What is a DSV?

A DSV is a specialised platform that allows a navy to sustain complex underwater operations for extended periods, particularly in deep and challenging waters. Naval operations often require divers and specialised teams to inspect, repair, recover or intervene around ships, submarines and other underwater assets. A DSV provides the diving systems, medical facilities and support needed for such missions, reducing dependence on shore-based facilities, and enabling quick response to underwater contingencies. The Navy undertakes extensive diving operations in the Indian Ocean Region for submarine rescue, underwater inspection, testing or salvage, and recovery of objects, ships or aircraft lost at sea. Earlier, the Navy operated Russian-origin submarine rescue vessels and relied on a mix of shore facilities along with specialised diving units and suitably equipped naval vessels. But these lacked the multidomain operational capabilities and ability of long deployments at sea. In 2018, the Navy signed a contract with Hindustan Shipyard Ltd, Vishakhapatnam, for construction of two DSVs, the first of which — INS Nistar — was commissioned in July 2025.

'Mother ship'

Admiral Krishna Swaminathan, Chief of the Naval Staff, said at the commissioning ceremony of the 9,000-tonne vessel: "Nipun adds specialised capability to support complex underwater operations and respond to emergencies in one of the most demanding and mysterious environments known to the world." Nipun is installed with dive equipment and can undertake deep-sea saturation diving — this denotes operations where divers live under pressure for long periods to work deep underwater. "A side diving stage has also been provided for undertaking diving operations. The remotely operated vehicles further enhance the ship's operational capabilities by facilitating diver monitoring and salvage operations," the Navy said. Nipun also serves as the "mother ship" for deep submergence rescue vessels (DSRVs) "to evacuate personnel in case of an emergency on a submarine", the Navy said. Currently, India has two DSRVs. Nipun has a self-propelled hyperbaric lifeboat — a pressurised lifeboat that can independently evacuate divers and diving compression chambers. It can help in recovering of damaged, sunken or stranded ships and equipment.

Maritime preparedness

"For a navy operating across the vast Indian Ocean Region, the ability to sustain specialised underwater operations at sea is an important part of preparedness. This is particularly relevant to submarine operations, where an accident or technical emergency can quickly become a race against time," a retired Navy officer, who has served on submarines, told *The Indian Express*.

For India, this is significant as underwater capabilities become increasingly important to maritime security. "The induction of indigenous DSVs also means the Navy is building and sustaining specialised expertise and equipment domestically, while strengthening its ability to provide submarine rescue assistance to regional partners," said the retired officer.

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• INDUS WATERS TREATY

With India rejecting Hague court order, the road ahead



AMITABH SINHA

THE PERMANENT Court of Arbitration, adjudicating on a dispute raised by Pakistan on the Indus Waters Treaty, has passed two more orders against India. It has ruled that India's decision to put the Treaty in 'abeyance' was "not permissible under the Treaty or other applicable rules of international law", and therefore the Treaty — which governs the sharing of six transboundary river waters between the two countries — remained "fully in force" and India continued to be bound by it. The Court also directed India to halt construction work at the Ratle Hydroelectric Project, as requested by Pakistan, till the technical dispute over it is settled. India has not been participating in this arbitration process, underway for four years, having maintained that the Court was constituted in violation of the provisions of the Treaty. A neutral expert had already been appointed to adjudicate on the same issue, and the Treaty does not allow parallel resolution processes on the same dispute. As such, India said the Court lacked legitimacy, and did not appoint its two arbitrators on the Court. The Court went ahead with its proceedings with two arbitrators appointed by Pakistan, and three 'umpires' nominated by institutions mentioned in the Treaty.

India's rejection

India's reaction to the two orders on Monday was on expected lines. "This so called Court was constituted by the World Bank in patent breach of the terms of the Treaty and India categorically rejects its so-called award... India's decision to hold the Indus Waters Treaty in abeyance remains in force," the Ministry of External Affairs said. The two set of rulings on Monday happened to be the fourth 'award' from the Court of Arbitration, set up in September 2022, to adjudicate on objections raised by Pakistan over the construction of a couple of hydropower projects in Jammu and Kashmir. All the 'awards' have, unsurprisingly, gone in favour of Pakistan. In its earlier 'awards', the Court has, among other things,

• THREE LEVELS OF DISPUTE RESOLUTION IN THE TREATY

Any 'question' over the interpretation or applicability of the Treaty has to be addressed first by the **Permanent Indus Commission**, comprising the Indus Commissioners of the two countries. If they are unable to resolve the 'question', a 'difference' is deemed to have arisen. If the nature of the 'difference' is one of the 23 different specified kinds, this can be referred to a **neutral expert**. If the nature of the 'difference' is something other than the 23 specified types, it is considered to have become a 'dispute', which needs to be adjudicated by a **Court of Arbitration**. The Court of Arbitration also comes into the picture if the neutral expert decides that the whole matter, or a



An IWT hearing at the Court of Arbitration, The Hague, in April.

part of it, should be treated as a 'dispute', or if both the parties decide on this route at any point of time. In the present case, there was no agreement between the two Commissioners to treat the 'difference' as a 'dispute'. Nor was there a recommendation from a neutral expert that it needed to be treated as a 'dispute'.

Also, the World Bank had set up a neutral expert at India's request. Setting up a Court of Arbitration on the same issue was about instituting a parallel process, which is not allowed in the Treaty. It could also lead to the absurdity of the two processes producing different and irreconcilable decisions.

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> Council. Another alternative would be to get the Security Council or the UN General Assembly to refer the matter to the International Court of Justice.

The treaty Under the Treaty, 'Eastern Rivers' of the Indus system — Sutlej, Beas and Ravi — are for India. Pakistan gets water from the 'Western Rivers' — Indus, Jhelum, and Chenab.

The Treaty allows India limited use of Western rivers too, but this has not been possible because of Pakistan's objections to anything India builds on them

With Monday's order, the Court has likely finished its work, having addressed all the issues raised by Pakistan. The Court has no means to get its orders enforced, and therefore, its orders will not bring about any material change. For Pakistan, however, the Court orders are very significant. It is almost sure to use these at every relevant international forum, and also to drive up hysteria against India within the country. These orders are key for it to explore further legal options at the international level.

Road ahead for Pakistan

The best case scenario for Pakistan would be to get the UN Security Council to pass a resolution against India, framing its dispute over the Treaty as a security issue. It has been working towards that aim, and is almost sure to take a shot at it during the remaining four months of its tenure as a non-permanent member of the Security

These are far-fetched scenarios, however, and unlikely to play out as per Pakistan's desires. India has much greater clout at the UN, and can get such moves scuttled. Besides these efforts, the other option for Pakistan is to try and create a narrative painting India as someone that does not respect international law or abide by treaty provisions. This is something that Pakistan is already indulging in, and the efforts are almost certain to intensify. India, besides creating a diplomatic counter-narrative, is preparing to fight the legal battle, if it becomes necessary. It is not that India does not have a legal case, and it is confident that it can defend its decision to put the Treaty in abeyance.

Road ahead for India

India's main focus is on expeditious completion of the projects that will allow it to make full use of its rights on the three western rivers — Indus, Jhelum and Chenab — allocated to Pakistan under the Treaty. The Treaty's provisions allow India to make limited use of these waters, but this has not been possible because of Pakistan's repeated objections to anything India tries to build on

• LEGAL

Distinguished jurist: The unused route to appoint an SC judge

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, September 1

DECADES AFTER the Constitution came into force, one route to becoming a Supreme Court judge has never been taken. At a convocation address on August 30, Supreme Court judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan pointed to Article 124(3), which allows the appointment of a "distinguished jurist" as a Supreme Court judge, and called it an "unused mandate" of the Constitution that "needs our serious attention." He said that having a distinguished jurist on the bench would "diversify the Bench" and that they "would not remain constricted by narrow technicalities thereby being in a stronger position to deal with public law issues." He said the "participation of... legal academia and scholars would have a defining impact on the judicial functioning of the Supreme Court."

What the Constitution states

Article 124 sets out how the Supreme Court is constituted. Article 124(3) lists who can be appointed as a judge, i.e., a citizen of

India who has either served as a High Court judge for five years, practised as an advocate for ten years, or "is, in the opinion of the President, a distinguished jurist." The first two routes are how the court has always been staffed. Most judges have been elevated from the High Courts, while a smaller number of lawyers have been appointed directly from the Bar. The most recent was Justice V Mohana, recommended by the collegium in May 2026 and sworn in the following month. The third category, the appointment of distinguished jurists, has simply never been used. Article 217 lays down the conditions for the appointment of a High Court judge. The 42nd Amendment, enacted during the Emergency, added a provision allowing the appointment of a "distinguished jurist" as a judge of the High Court. However, the provision was eventually repealed by the 44th Constitutional Amendment.

Where the clause came from

The clause was added during the Constituent Assembly debates on May 24, 1949, after H V Kamath moved an amendment

Appointing a judge: 3 ways

The Constitution sets out who can be made a SC judge: a citizen of India who has either served as a HC judge for 5 years; practised as an advocate for ten years; or 'is, in the opinion of the President, a distinguished jurist'. The first two routes are how the court has always been staffed. The third route has never been used.

saying the pool of candidates shouldn't be "necessarily confined to Judges or Advocates." He said that India needed a way to bring in "men or for that matter, women who are possessed of outstanding legal and juristic learning," even if they had never practised law. He pointed out that judges of the International Court of Justice at The Hague are chosen on similar terms. B R Ambedkar didn't object to the idea itself. His only hesitation was over the word "distinguished", and he wondered whether "eminent" would be a better fit. He, however, left the final call to the Drafting Committee. The amendment eventually went through. Who qualifies & why no one has Justice Bhuyan offered two possible explanations for why the clause remains unused. "The first is that earlier in the view of the central government and thereafter of the collegium, there is not enough depth in the Indian academia to be considered for elevation as a judge of the Supreme Court. The second is that both the central government and the collegium have not seriously explored this provision thus far," he said.

A "distinguished jurist" is generally understood to be anyone engaged in serious work in the practice, teaching or research of law, including those who do not require courtroom experience to fit the description. But this interpretation runs into a separate problem in India, where the Bar Council rules generally prevent full-time law teachers from practising law. A further complication is the process of Supreme Court appointments itself. Appointments today are initiated through the collegium system, meaning that a jurist would first have to be recommended by the Supreme Court collegium before the appointment goes to the government. In an interview in 2015 with *LiveLaw*, Upendra Baxi recalled being addressed as "Judge Baxi" by a professor, who had been told by Justice P N Bhagwati that Baxi would be made a judge within a few months. That appointment never materialised. Addressing the matter, Baxi said that "the Presidents of India have been looking with a telescope and have not found any jurist worth appointing as a Supreme Court Judge" and thus called it "a dead issue."

• NEPAL DISASTER

Why risk-monitoring in the Himalayas is like looking for 'needles in haystacks'



EXPERT EXPLAINS
AUSTIN LORD

SENIOR FELLOW AT STIMSON CENTER

THE FLOODS in Nepal have raised fresh questions about how well the Himalayas are prepared for rapidly evolving and cascading climatic and geological hazards. **Austin Lord**, a Senior Fellow with the Energy, Water and Sustainability Program at the US-based non-profit thinktank Stimson Center, has been closely examining the region's evolving hazard landscape. In an interview with **Nikhil Ghanekar**, Lord discusses the sequence of events, the risk of 'hazard constellations', and the lessons the disaster holds for Nepal and the wider Himalayas. Edited excerpts:

What was the trigger and sequence of the Nepal flood?
The present consensus is that the initial trigger was a glacial detachment that included bedrock on the northern slopes of Langtang Lirung, a 7,000-plus-metre peak in the Langtang range. The exact triggering process is not entirely understood. That could be related to climate-related risks or gradual shifts at the site. Preliminary analysis indicates there may have been some minor movement of the glacial mass in the weeks or months before the event, followed by a tipping point. Once it failed, it swept down through a gully toward the Lhende River, which reaches the Chinese border. The source area was around 5,200 metres, so the flow descended a couple of thousand metres. It deposited a mixture of ice, rock and sediment, creating a temporary natural dam that blocked the river. There is still debate about how much water came from the glacier itself, from the melting of entrained ice, and from water that accumulated behind the landslide dam. The dam failed and sent a major pulse

of water downstream. The event reached the China border in roughly nine minutes. Footage from the Gyirong border facility shows a massive dark wave containing not just water but a large volume of material. The border facility was at a confluence with another tributary, the Gyirong River. The flow then continued downstream. Within seconds of hitting the Chinese facility, it was already moving back into Nepal. There was no realistic opportunity for people at the facility to warn communities downstream; many of those who could have generated an alert were themselves swept away. The flow then destroyed dams and hydropower projects downstream, recruited additional sediment, and swept through villages along the river corridor. The event continued into Nuwakot district and affected larger market towns in the floodplain. These affected areas are well beyond the 100-year or 500-year floodplain. This was a thousand-year-plus flood event, with significant impacts extending more than 100 kilometres downstream. The flood pulse also registered at

the India-Nepal border. The larger issue is the increasing frequency and intensity of cascading hazard chains. We have seen this in Chamoli; Sikkim, with the South Lhonak GLOF (glacial lake outburst flood); and in Nepal with the Melamchi disaster. Climate risks are interacting with and amplifying other disaster risks. These events are becoming more frequent and more intense. Was the failed glacier identified as a vulnerable site? Several places around Nepal have been identified as high-risk areas for glacial detachment and surges. There are glaciers immediately on the other side of Langtang Lirung that are high-priority research sites. But this particular location had no red flags. Even now, we are examining whether changes could have been detected in the days leading up to the event, but that would still require knowing where to look. Monitoring every glacier and every mountainside that could collapse is like looking for needles in haystacks. You need some signal to separate from the noise.

That is why remote sensing and satellite-based analysis are important, but different satellite tools answer different questions, and you have to know where to look. To know where to look, it's important to engage local communities. Of over a dozen extreme events in the Himalayas over 10 years, almost all came from unknown places, except the South Lhonak GLOF which was a known risk. We are beginning to identify patterns, but there is no training dataset from the Alps or Norway that can simply be transferred to the Himalayas. The Himalayas have their own context and significant data scarcity and data sparsity. What is the broader lesson for India, Nepal and the Himalayas? The kind of mapping exercise undertaken by India's Home Ministry and space agencies (to monitor glacial lakes and hazards) is an absolute necessity. It provides a baseline. Nepal does not have the same level of resources, and although some mapping has been done, it is not as comprehensive. Once you have those maps, you can

begin hazard zoning and modelling. But the key is monitoring. Remote sensing and satellite imagery are one part of the triangle. The second is fixed station networks — hydromet and seismic stations. The third is localised monitoring. You need to engage local governments, disaster managers and Community Disaster Management Committees. They can collect local data, report landslides and monitor impacts after storms. You also need people who are immersed in these environments. Yak herders and fishermen can notice changes in rivers, glaciers and glacial lakes. Oral histories with elders can reveal smaller avalanches, glacial-lake floods and other events that science has not recorded, helping identify potential hotspots. When you combine the station network, remote sensing and localised monitoring, you have a better chance of detecting changes and distinguishing the signal from the noise that tells you where to look. FULL INTERVIEW ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM